



SERY

THIN LIFELINE:
Flood victims
defied death but
now fall prey to
disease; (below)
activists protest
lack of medicare

fact, more than two lakh people have already migrated.

A frantic search is also on for those who are missing. This is also because many families, despite being otherwise eligible for an ex-gratia compensation of Rs 1.5 lakh, are faced with the daunting task of proving that those missing have indeed died. The trouble is a law that states someone could be presumed to be dead only after being missing for seven years. So usually a death certificate, which is a pre-requisite for government compensation, is issued only after this period, in case the body of the victim is not traced. Residents believe that this would make things difficult for relatives of those who were "swept away". Incidentally, the rescue teams have already evacuated almost a million people from the marooned villages, according to the Disaster Management Department, while only about one lakh people were left to be shifted to safe land. Officials also believe that another million people may have moved out to safe locations without any government help.

But the government figures leave one with a mathematical puzzle. One million people rescued plus one million people who moved out on their own plus one lakh still stranded just don't make it to 30.69 lakh—the number of people the state has accepted to have been affected. On the other hand, the state Government officially accepts only 141 deaths caused by the Kosi waters. Even this figure has climbed by over 400 per cent in one week. Last week, government had declared 30 dead. The calculation, however, still leaves us with a possibility of hundreds of possible missing individuals in the aftermath of the flood.

A good three weeks later, the disaster management authorities have decided to start missing people cells in flood-affected districts. In addition to this, a toll-free number has been installed where people can get their complaints recorded about missing persons. The official casualty figures seem too conservative given the enormity of the situation. Unofficial sources put the toll much higher. Meanwhile,



"The magnitude of the destruction is more than we can handle."

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